

CHAPTER ONE: "THE BRAINIAC KID"

The Real-World Story · Chapter 1 · THE STORY HAS BEGUN

Friday, April 28, 2006 → Friday, September 29, 2006

Rating: TV-MA (L)

BLACK SCREEN.

TITLE CARD:

"The following footage was recorded between 2006 and 2019 by an independent documentary crew.

The crew set out to make a film about child stars who were trying to grow up.

They ended up somewhere else.

The footage was sealed under agreement with Marvel Studios and could not be shown until the story was finished."

CUT TO:

COLD OPEN

INT. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK'S HOUSE — KITCHEN — BALDWIN HILLS,
LOS ANGELES — PRE-DAWN
FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 — 5:51 AM PT

A big, warm kitchen that nobody decorated. Cereal boxes lined up like trophies. A framed Sundance laurel propped against the toaster. Through the window, the lights of the city are still on.

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (24, looks 19) is at the stove in a Crenshaw High hoodie and pajama pants covered in cartoon rocket ships. He has not slept. He is making pancakes for the DOCUMENTARY CREW (a camera operator, a boom op, and the DIRECTOR, who is always off-camera).

He flips a pancake. It lands perfectly.

MARC-ANTHONY

Seven for seven. You guys want chocolate chips? I'm doing a chocolate chip one. I'm doing a chocolate chip one whether you want it or not, because I'm about to lose my entire [BLEEP]ing mind.

His BLACKBERRY buzzes on the counter. He jumps. Looks at it.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

It's my mom. It's just my mom.

(answers)

Hi Mommy. - No. - No, I'm up. - Nine minutes. I know. I can see the clock, I have a clock, I'm looking at it right -

(listens)

...I love you too.

(hangs up; to camera)

She called to tell me it's in nine minutes. Like I didn't know it's in nine minutes. I've known it's in nine minutes for FOUR HOURS.

He slides the pancake onto a plate and hands it to the boom operator, who has to take it one-handed.

DIRECTOR (O.S.)

What happens in nine minutes?

Marc looks at the lens for a long second. Then he grins, the grin of a kid who's about to get in trouble.

MARC-ANTHONY

In nine minutes, a press release goes out on the East Coast. And then everybody finds out. And half this town is gonna laugh.

(beat)

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

Let 'em.

He turns off the burner.

HARD CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD:
"FIVE MONTHS EARLIER"

THE LEDGER: WHO'S WHO, AND HOW OLD (as of Friday, April 28, 2006)

Person	Born	Age	Where they are today
Marc-Anthony Bullock	Jan 5, 1982	24 (<i>looks 19</i>)	Nine months without a greenlit project
Amond Baker	Feb 10, 1982	24 (<i>looks 19</i>)	His sitcom is about to be canceled
Tayia Boyd	Feb 3, 1982	24 (<i>looks 19</i>)	Season 1 of <i>Two Doors Down</i> (NBC)
Esther Smiley	Sep 20, 1982	23 (<i>looks 16</i>)	Voicing a talking hedgehog
Grace Bullock	Apr 12, 1984	22 (<i>looks 17</i>)	Turned 22 sixteen days ago
Elxa Bullock	Aug 29, 1980	25 (<i>looks 21</i>)	Hosting <i>Elxa After Dark</i> (D1)
Natasha Bullock	Jun 2, 1961	44 (<i>looks early 30s</i>)	CEO, Donohue Entertainment
Robert Bullock	Feb 10, 1959	47 (<i>looks late 30s</i>)	Prepping a film
Victor Donohue	May 30, 1936	69	Still in the office every Monday
Joan Donohue	Apr 17, 1938	68	Just back from New Orleans
Kevin Feige	Jun 2, 1973	32	Marvel Studios, and a whiteboard
Avi Arad	Apr 1, 1948	58	Marvel Studios founder
Jon Favreau	Oct 19, 1966	39	About to be hired
Barry Kessler (<i>Marc's agent</i>)	Nov 3, 1948	57	Pinnacle Artists Agency
Stan Lee	Dec 28, 1922	83	Everywhere

ARCHIVAL: THE FEIGE TAPES

ARCHIVAL FOOTAGE – "MARVEL STUDIOS, DAY BY DAY"
HOME VIDEO, SHOT ON KEVIN FEIGE'S PERSONAL SONY HANDYCAM
(Donated to the documentary in 2006. Never before seen.)

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS – 9242 BEVERLY BLVD – SECOND FLOOR –
BEVERLY HILLS – MORNING
FRIDAY, APRIL 28, 2006 – 7:38 AM PT

Shaky consumer video. A timestamp burned into the corner. Cramped offices. Long boxes of comics stacked along the walls like sandbags. Downstairs, through the floor, somebody is test-driving an S-Class.

Feige's own voice, behind the camera.

KEVIN FEIGE (O.S.)
April twenty-eighth, two thousand
six. Seven thirty-eight. It's
going out at nine Eastern.

He turns the camera on the room. AVI ARAD (58), in a leather jacket and sunglasses indoors, is reading a fax. DAVID MAISEL, Marvel Studios' chairman, calm, in a suit with no tie, has a laptop open.

AVI ARAD
Turn that off, Kevin.

KEVIN FEIGE (O.S.)
Somebody should write down what
happened today.

AVI ARAD
Nothing happened today. Today
we hired a director. Tomorrow
something happens. In two years
something happens.

DAVID MAISEL
Today we told the world we're
making a movie, Avi. That's
something.

Arad drops the fax on the desk. A draft PRESS RELEASE. We can read the headline:

MARVEL STUDIOS NAMES JON FAVREAU TO DIRECT "IRON MAN,"
FIRST FILM OF ITS INDEPENDENT SLATE

AVI ARAD
Ten years. Ten years they called
me. Sony, Fox, Universal, Warner.
"Avi, give us Spider-Man. Avi,
name your number."
(taps the page)
I said no to a hundred million
dollars. You know what they call
me in this town? "The man who
said no."

DAVID MAISEL

They also call you other things.

AVI ARAD

Those I don't repeat in front
of a camera.

The camera swings to a WHITEBOARD on the far wall. It's covered
by a bedsheet, thumbtacked at the corners.

KEVIN FEIGE (O.S.)

And this stays covered.

DAVID MAISEL

That stays covered until I'm
dead.

KEVIN FEIGE (O.S.)

(quietly)

Until it's done.

MEDIA INSERT: THE ANNOUNCEMENT

PR NEWSWIRE | Friday, April 28, 2006, 9:00 AM ET

MARVEL STUDIOS NAMES JON FAVREAU TO DIRECT "IRON MAN"

NEW YORK / LOS ANGELES — Marvel Studios, a division of Marvel Entertainment, Inc. (NYSE: MVL), today announced that Jon Favreau (Elf, Zathura) will direct Iron Man, the first feature film to be produced under Marvel's independent financing structure. The film will be distributed worldwide by Paramount Pictures. "For the first time in its history, Marvel will bring one of its characters to the big screen itself, on its own terms," said Avi Arad, Chairman and CEO of Marvel Studios. The film is targeted for release in summer 2008.

VARIETY | Friday, April 28, 2006

FAVREAU SUITS UP FOR MARVEL'S 'IRON MAN'

'Elf' helmer will make the first-ever feature starring a Marvel Comics character, as the comics company gambles its own money on a second-string hero. Marvel has famously refused for a decade to license characters such as Spider-Man and the X-Men to the majors.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER | April 28, 2006

MARVEL'S FIRST MOVIE IS... IRON MAN?

Analysts puzzled that the company is opening its film slate with a B-list character. "It's like Disney opening a theme park and building the Goofy ride first," said one studio exec.

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS | April 28, 2006, 7:12 AM CT

HOLY [BLEEP]. MARVEL IS MAKING A MOVIE. AN ACTUAL MARVEL MOVIE.

I have waited my whole life to type that sentence, and now that I get to type it, it's about Iron Man. Favreau is a fanboy, and that's the best news of the day. Now: who plays Tony? DO NOT screw this up.

NEWSARAMA | April 28, 2006

STAN LEE ON 'IRON MAN': "IT'S ABOUT TIME!"

The 83-year-old Marvel legend, reached at his POW! Entertainment offices: "I created Iron Man in 1963 as a challenge. Everybody hated weapons makers. I wanted to make them love one! Now let's see if Hollywood can make you love him. Excelsior!"

SUPERHEROHYPER.COM FORUMS › Marvel Studios › "OFFICIAL: MARVEL STUDIOS' FIRST FILM IS IRON MAN (Favreau to direct)"

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ShellHead_1963 — Apr 28 2006, 6:04 AM

IT'S REAL. IT'S ACTUALLY REAL. THE FIRST MARVEL MOVIE IN HISTORY AND IT'S SHELLHEAD. I have been Iron Man's number one fan since 1981. I'm crying at my desk.

XxWolverineXx — Apr 28 2006, 6:11 AM

lol. The first Marvel movie ever made, after 40 years of waiting, and it's IRON MAN? Not Spider-Man. Not the X-Men. IRON MAN. The guy who's famous for being an alcoholic. This company has five thousand characters and they picked the one my dad reads.

Webhead4Ever — Apr 28 2006, 6:15 AM

They're scared. Spider-Man is too big to fail, so they're testing with a guy nobody will miss if it flops. Smart honestly.

ExcelsiorFaithful — Apr 28 2006, 6:22 AM

Doesn't matter who. Only question: IS IT COMIC ACCURATE? Afghanistan? Yinsen? Stane as Iron Monger? If they make up a villain I'm out.

XxWolverineXx — Apr 28 2006, 6:24 AM

@ExcelsiorFaithful You're gonna get a Tony Stark who's a 40-year-old action guy with a goatee and a CGI suit, and you're gonna like it, because it's all we get.

Mjolnir_Worthy — Apr 28 2006, 6:40 AM

Guys. Batman & Robin. Catwoman. Steel. Superman Returns is coming out in June and everyone's already calling it a bomb. Hollywood is DONE with capes. And Marvel is putting its own money on this. Either these people are geniuses or it's the dumbest thing I've ever seen.

ShellHead_1963 — Apr 28 2006, 6:41 AM

Iron Man doesn't wear a cape.

MYSPLACE | Bulletin from ~Brainiac Fan 4 Life~ (Top 8: Marc-Anthony Bullock Official), Apr 28 2006, 10:17 PM

omg did anybody see marvel is making an IRON MAN movie?? tony stark is a genius who builds robot suits. you know who played a genius who built robot suits for 4 YEARS?? just saying. MARC FOR TONY. repost if u agree!!!! 100 100

SCENE 1

INT. PINNACLE ARTISTS AGENCY — BARRY KESSLER'S OFFICE —
CENTURY CITY — DAY
FRIDAY, APRIL 28, 2006 — 11:32 AM PT

Corner office, 31st floor. Glass. Framed one-sheets on every wall: BIG MOUTH (1997). PLEDGE WEEK (2004). The Brainiac cast photo, signed "TO UNCLE BARRY."

BARRY KESSLER (57), deep tan, reading glasses on a chain, the kind of agent who has sent the same fruit basket for thirty years. He loves Marc-Anthony like a son. He also has not had a clue what to do with him for fourteen months.

Marc-Anthony sits across from him, with his feet on the chair next to his. The documentary CAMERA sits in the corner. This is the crew's fifth day with him.

Barry slides a SCRIPT across the desk. The cover page reads:

"DOUBLE BOGEY"

BARRY

Before you say anything. Before
you say one word. Warner Bros.
Two point five against five. And
Owen Wilson wants to do it.

Marc picks up the script and flips to the last page, then to the first page, then puts it down.

MARC-ANTHONY

Barry. I'm a caddy.

BARRY

You're the caddy! You're the
heart of it!

MARC-ANTHONY

On page four, a golf cart runs
over my [BLEEP]. On page
sixty-one, a goose runs over my
[BLEEP]. I'm counting. That's
a franchise. That's the
[BLEEP]-getting-run-over
trilogy.

BARRY

Comedy is pain.

MARC-ANTHONY
Comedy is pain, yes. It's not
PAIN specifically to the —

BARRY
— it's the eighth comedy you've
said no to, Marc.

A beat. Marc takes his feet off the chair.

MARC-ANTHONY
Eighth. You're counting too.

BARRY
(gentler)
Kid. I've had you since you were
five. You were in the cereal ad.
The one with the spoon. I love
you. I'm telling you as somebody
who loves you. The town has two
pictures of you in its head. The
Brainiac kid...

MARC-ANTHONY
...and the Brainiac kid who says
[BLEEP] on HBO.

BARRY
The drama didn't work. I know the
drama was beautiful. My wife cried.
My wife doesn't cry at anything,
she didn't cry at our wedding.
But four point two million, Marc.
Four point two.

MARC-ANTHONY
(quiet)
I know what it made.

Barry's computer PINGS. He glances at it. It's the Variety
headline. He almost doesn't mention it, then does.

BARRY
Marvel's making a movie. You see
this? Iron Man. Favreau's
directing.

Marc goes very still.

BARRY (CONT'D)
Crazy people. Putting their own
money on a comic book. You know

what Superman cost? And Superman,
people have HEARD of.

MARC-ANTHONY
Tony Stark is an engineer.

BARRY
Who's Tony Stark?

MARC-ANTHONY
Iron Man. He's an engineer. He's
a genius engineer who drinks too
much and talks too much and he
builds himself a suit in a cave
with a box of scraps because he's
dying.

(beat)
I have a mechanical engineering
degree, Barry.

BARRY
I know. I was at the graduation.
I cried.

MARC-ANTHONY
You said your wife doesn't cry.

BARRY
I CRY. My wife doesn't cry.
(beat; he sees Marc's face)
No. No, no, no. Marc. It's a
comic book. Comic book movies are
poison right now. Everybody in
this building will tell you. If
it bombs, it follows you forever.
You'd be "the Brainiac kid who
was in the comic book bomb."

MARC-ANTHONY
At least it'd be a new sentence.

He stands. Picks up DOUBLE BOGEY. Puts it back on Barry's
desk, gently, like he's tucking it into bed.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
Tell Owen I said he's gonna be
great.

TALKING HEAD

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S CAR (A 1987 BUICK GRAND NATIONAL, BLACK)
— PARKED, CENTURY CITY GARAGE — DAY

LOWER THIRD: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK
Actor · Age 24
Recorded Friday, April 28, 2006

He's in the driver's seat, with the camera in the passenger seat. He isn't driving anywhere.

MARC-ANTHONY
So when I was fourteen, on
Brainiac, we did an episode where
Marcus builds a robot suit for the
science fair. Tinfoil. Cardboard.
I had a line: "One day, a man will
fly in a suit of armor!" And then
the helmet falls off and hits the
judge on the foot.
(smiles)
I kept the helmet. It's in my
closet. Tinfoil helmet, in a
closet, like a crazy person.
(beat)
Everybody thinks I read comics
because I'm a nerd. I read comics
because when I was nine I was on
a TV show, and every other kid I
knew was forty years old. The only
people my age in my life were in
the comic books.
(looks at the lens)
Tony Stark was my friend. That's
a stupid thing to say. Put it in
the movie anyway.

SCENE 2

EXT./INT. THE DONOHUE ESTATE — VIEW PARK — DINING ROOM —
NIGHT
TUESDAY, MAY 30, 2006 — 7:48 PM PT

VICTOR DONOHUE'S 70TH BIRTHDAY.

A Spanish Colonial house on a hill with a view of the whole basin. Inside, a long dining table set for twelve. A cake

shaped like a vinyl record: "70 – STILL SPINNING."

At the head: VICTOR DONOHUE (70 today; looks mid-50s), silver cardigan, a voice like good brandy. At the other end: JOAN DONOHUE (68, looks early 50s), who sees everything and says a quarter of it.

Between them: NATASHA BULLOCK (44), ROBERT BULLOCK (47), ELXA (25), in a gown that probably has a waiting list, and GRACE (22), who's sitting on the arm of Marc-Anthony's chair because she wants to.

The documentary crew has been allowed in. Joan has made it very clear that they are allowed in "for now."

ELXA

– I'm just saying, if Tony Stark has a sister, I'm available.

NATASHA

Tony Stark doesn't have a sister.

ELXA

Tony Stark doesn't have a sister
YET.

GRACE

If Marc does this and they give him a girlfriend and she's some blonde from a shampoo commercial, I'm burning down the building.

MARC-ANTHONY

Nobody has given me anything.
Nobody has CALLED me. I don't have a meeting. I don't have an audition. Barry thinks I'm having a breakdown. I have a tinfoil helmet and a dream.

VICTOR

Who's making it?

MARC-ANTHONY

Marvel. Their own money. They went to Merrill Lynch and put their characters up as collateral. If the movies fail, the bank keeps Captain America.

Victor puts his fork down. The table gets a little quieter. Everyone knows what it means when Victor puts his fork down.

VICTOR

Say that again.

MARC-ANTHONY

If the movie fails, the bank
keeps –

VICTOR

No. The first part. They made it
with their own money.

MARC-ANTHONY

Every studio in town tried to buy
Spider-Man off them for ten years.
And the guy who runs it said no.
Every single time.

Victor leans back. He looks at Joan down the length of the
table. Something passes between them that is forty-six years
old.

VICTOR

Nineteen seventy-two. Motown's
just moved to L.A., everybody's
buying everybody. A man from
Columbia sits in my office on
Crenshaw – the laundromat, the
dryers still in the walls – and
he says, "Victor. Eleven million
dollars. For the masters and the
name." Eleven million dollars in
nineteen seventy-two.

(beat)

I said, "Get out of my laundromat."

GRACE

(to the camera)

He says this at every birthday.

JOAN

He says it at every funeral.

VICTOR

Because it's true at every
funeral.

(to Marc)

A man who won't sell what he owns
knows exactly what it's worth.
You go to that man. And you make
him see what YOU'RE worth.

NATASHA
Daddy, he doesn't have a meeting.

VICTOR
Then get him one, Natasha. You
run the company.

NATASHA
(a small, dangerous smile)
I've already made two calls.

Marc turns to his mother.

MARC-ANTHONY
You WHAT?

NATASHA
Eat your cake.

ROBERT, who has said nothing all night, puts a hand on his
son's shoulder.

ROBERT
Whatever they ask you to read,
don't try to be funny.

MARC-ANTHONY
Dad, I'm always funny.

ROBERT
I know. Don't TRY. Let it happen
to you. The camera sees you
trying. It sees everything.
(beat)
The man's dying in a cave. Play
the cave. The jokes come from the
cave.

Marc looks at his father. That lands.

VICTOR
Now somebody sing me the song
before I get older.

The whole table sings "Happy Birthday," led by Grace, who
takes it up an octave on "dear Victor" and holds the note
until Joan puts a hand on her arm.

TALKING HEAD

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — THE MUSIC ROOM — NIGHT

LOWER THIRD: JOAN DONOHUE

Director · Actress · Grandmother · Age 68

Recorded Tuesday, May 30, 2006

In a wingback chair, beside a Steinway nobody is allowed to put a drink on.

JOAN

My grandson is the funniest person
I've ever known, and I've known
Richard Pryor.

(beat)

And he is the sweetest. Those two
things don't usually come in one
body. Usually the funny ones are
angry. Marc isn't angry. Marc is
scared.

(looks at the camera)

He's scared that everyone's right
about him. That he's a little boy
on a Disney show who got lucky.

(beat)

Put that in your movie too. Then
put in the part where he proves
them wrong. I'll wait.

SCENE 3

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT — NATASHA'S OFFICE — THE CRENSHAW
LOT — DAY

FRIDAY, JUNE 2, 2006 — 10:05 AM PT

The top floor of the old administration building. Gold and
platinum records. A framed still from BLUE HOUR (1987):
Natasha at 26, in a sequined gown, singing into a ribbon mic.
Birthday flowers on every surface: today she turns 45.

NATASHA (45 today) sits behind the desk. Phone on speaker. The
documentary camera is in the corner. She lets it stay because
she wants a record of this.

ASSISTANT (V.O.)

(intercom)

Mrs. Bullock? Kevin Feige,

Marvel Studios. Line two.

Natasha picks up. A beat before she speaks. She sits up a little straighter.

NATASHA
Mr. Feige.

INTERCUT WITH:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS — KEVIN FEIGE'S OFFICE — BEVERLY HILLS —
SAME TIME

A shoebox of an office. Comics everywhere. An Angels cap on the desk lamp. KEVIN FEIGE (33 today) holds the phone with both hands, like it might get away. His Handycam is on a stack of trades, recording.

FEIGE
Mrs. Bullock. Thank you for calling. Twice. And I'm sorry it took me a week to call you back.

NATASHA
I have heard of worse. What I'm not used to is being called back by the man at the top of the building. I asked for a casting director.

FEIGE
Our casting director is on a plane. And I wanted to be the one who told you.

NATASHA
Told me what?

FEIGE
That I've had your son's name on my wall since January two thousand five.

Silence on Natasha's end.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Sundance. The Long Way Home. The scene at the kitchen table, where the father's reading the letter out loud and he can't finish it, and your son takes it out of his hand and finishes it for him, and he

starts making a joke halfway through because he can't – because it's too much, and then he stops joking.

(beat)

I went back to the hotel and wrote "TONY" on a Post-it. It's still on the wall. I can see it from here.

Natasha closes her eyes for a second.

NATASHA

Then why am I calling you, Mr. Feige, and not the other way around?

FEIGE

Because until five weeks ago, I didn't have a movie. And until last week, I didn't have a director who'd watched it too.

(beat)

Jon watched it Tuesday. He called me at one in the morning.

NATASHA

And what did Mr. Favreau say at one in the morning?

FEIGE

He said, "Why is this kid making frat movies?"

Natasha laughs, a real laugh, one her assistants almost never hear.

NATASHA

I have been asking that question for two years.

(all business again)

He'll want to meet. Not audition. Meet.

FEIGE

He'll want both. I'm not going to lie to you about that. Paramount will want a screen test. And they won't love the idea, Mrs. Bullock. I need you to hear me say that.

NATASHA

Why won't they love it?

A pause. Feige chooses the honest answer.

FEIGE

Because he's the Brainiac kid.
Because he's the kid who curses
on HBO. Because he's twenty-four.

(beat)

And because some people in some
rooms are going to say the other
thing, and they won't say it out
loud, and I'm going to have to
fight them on it without them ever
saying it.

NATASHA

(very quiet)

You know what the other thing is.

FEIGE

Yes, ma'am.

NATASHA

And you're still calling.

FEIGE

Tony Stark is a genius, and he's
the funniest man in every room,
and he's so scared of dying that he
builds a suit out of scraps in a
cave. I read the comics for a
living, Mrs. Bullock. That's your
son. That's all I've got. That's
the whole argument.

Natasha looks out at the lot. Her father's laundromat is
across the street, still standing.

NATASHA

Mr. Feige, when's your birthday?

FEIGE

(thrown)

...Today, actually.

NATASHA

June second?

FEIGE

June second, seventy-three.

NATASHA

June second, sixty-one. Happy

birthday, Kevin.

FEIGE
(after a moment)
Happy birthday, Natasha.

NATASHA
He'll be there. Tell me when.

TALKING HEAD

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS – A STORAGE CLOSET CONVERTED INTO AN
OFFICE – DAY

LOWER THIRD: KEVIN FEIGE
Executive Vice President of Production,
Marvel Studios · Age 33
Recorded Friday, August 18, 2006

(This interview was recorded later, after the agreement in
Scene 6. It's placed here by the editors.)

Angels cap. Diet Coke. A wall of Post-its behind him, facing
the wall so the camera can't read them.

FEIGE
I think everybody thinks it's
about the jokes. With Marc. They
think we're casting the funny guy.
(shakes his head)
We're casting the moment right
after the joke. Tony makes a joke
when he's about to fall apart. The
joke is a wall. Marc knows how to
build that wall better than anybody
I've ever seen.
(beat)
And he knows how to let you see
behind it for half a second.
That's the whole character. That's
fifty years of comics in half a
second.

MEDIA INSERT: THE SUMMER OF RUMORS

THE VELVET ROPE (anonymous gossip blog, "Velvet") | Tuesday, June 13, 2006, 11:44 PM

SPOTTED: A BULLOCK IN BEVERLY HILLS 🙄🙄

A little velvet birdie saw MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK's black Buick parked outside a certain car dealership on Beverly Blvd. Now why would the Brainiac baby need a Mercedes when he has that ugly old Buick he loves more than his own mother? Unless... the building has an upstairs? Velvet's saying nothing. Velvet's just saying. 

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS | Friday, June 30, 2006

IRON MAN CASTING RUMOR ROUNDUP: The names we're hearing

Every agent in town is calling Marvel. We're hearing big names, weird names, and one name that made me spit out my coffee: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK. Yes. The 'Brainiac' kid. My first reaction was "no way." My second reaction, after rewatching his Sundance movie at 2 AM, was "...wait."

SUPERHEROHYPE FORUMS | "IRON MAN CASTING THREAD #4" · Page 88 of 140

XxWolverineXx — Jun 30 2006, 8:12 AM

if it's the Disney Channel kid I will personally drive to Beverly Hills

ShellHead_1963 — Jun 30 2006, 8:19 AM

Have you seen The Long Way Home?

XxWolverineXx — Jun 30 2006, 8:20 AM

no, I have a life

ShellHead_1963 — Jun 30 2006, 8:21 AM

you have 11,000 posts on a superhero forum

XxWolverineXx — Jun 30 2006, 8:21 AM

that IS my life

BOX OFFICE MOJO | Weekend of June 30 – July 2, 2006

SUPERMAN RETURNS opens to \$52.5M over the three-day weekend (Wednesday opening). Analysts: "solid, not super." Industry chatter already calling the \$200M+ film a disappointment.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER | Monday, July 10, 2006

CAPE FEAR: 'Superman' stumble rattles comic-book slates

"If Superman can't fly, what makes Marvel think Iron Man can?" asked one studio chief. Sources say Marvel's 'Iron Man' casting has "gone young and unexpected."

SCENE 4

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS – THE CONFERENCE ROOM – DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 13, 2006 – 2:10 PM PT

"Conference room" is generous. It's a room with a table, eight mismatched chairs, and a window over the dealership lot. A salesman below is pointing at tires.

JON FAVREAU (39), baseball cap, cargo shorts, a producer's notebook he never writes in. KEVIN FEIGE (33), across the table. MARC-ANTHONY (24), in a blazer his mother made him wear, which he has already taken off and hung on the back of his chair.

The documentary crew is NOT in the room. This scene is from KEVIN FEIGE'S HANDYCAM, propped on a filing cabinet with a blinking red light.

FAVREAU

I'm not gonna have you read.

MARC-ANTHONY

Oh thank God.

FAVREAU

I'm gonna have you talk. You know Tony Stark?

MARC-ANTHONY

Tales of Suspense thirty-nine.
March nineteen sixty-three. Stan Lee, Larry Lieber, Don Heck, Jack Kirby did the cover. He's hit by shrapnel in Vietnam – which you're moving to Afghanistan, because of the sliding timescale, which, correct, good, Extremis already did it – and he builds the suit with Ho Yinsen, and Yinsen dies so Tony can get out.

(beat)

Do you want me to keep going?
I can keep going. I can go for like an hour. I'm going to stop.

Favreau looks at Feige. Feige is trying not to smile.

FAVREAU

Why do you want this?

MARC-ANTHONY
Honest answer or audition answer?

FAVREAU
There's a difference?

MARC-ANTHONY
Audition answer is, "It's a
fascinating character study of a
man confronting his legacy."

FAVREAU
And the honest one.

Marc-Anthony picks at the label on his water bottle. It takes
him a moment.

MARC-ANTHONY
He's the guy everyone thinks they
know. Rich, famous, funny, a
little gross. Everybody thinks
they have him figured out.
(beat)
And then he's in a cave with a
hole in his chest, and he's the
smartest guy on Earth, and he's
gonna die, and nobody's coming.
And the only thing he's got is
what he knows how to build.
(beat)
I haven't worked in a year. I
know what it's like to be the guy
everybody thinks they know.
(tries to lighten it)
I don't have the hole in my chest
yet. Give it time. Give Hollywood
another six months.

Favreau doesn't laugh. He writes something in the notebook
for the first time.

FAVREAU
What'd you write?

MARC-ANTHONY
...You're asking me what you
wrote?

FAVREAU
(turns it around)
Read it.

It says, in block letters: "PLAY THE CAVE."

Marc-Anthony stares at it.

MARC-ANTHONY

My dad said that.

FAVREAU

Your dad's Robert Bullock?
Harbor Street?

MARC-ANTHONY

Yeah.

FAVREAU

Then your dad's right, and I'm
stealing it.

TALKING HEAD

INT. A GUEST HOUSE IN LOS FELIZ — FAVREAU'S "OFFICE" — DAY

LOWER THIRD: JON FAVREAU

Director, "Iron Man" · Age 39

Recorded Tuesday, September 19, 2006

A couch. A stack of Iron Man trade paperbacks. A mini-fridge.

FAVREAU

I got a lot of calls. Every agent
in town has a guy who "is" Tony
Stark.

(shrugs)

And then there's this kid who
knows the issue numbers. Who
knows the inker. And then in the
middle of a joke he stops, and
you see him decide not to say it.

(beat)

That's the hardest thing to direct.
You can't teach somebody to decide
not to say the joke. He just does
it.

SCENE 5

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS — STAGE 5 — HOLLYWOOD — DAY
WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 16, 2006 — 9:58 AM PT

THE SCREEN TEST.

A bare stage dressed as a cave: rock-textured flats, a workbench, scrap metal, a single hanging bulb. Two cameras. Paramount has sent THREE EXECUTIVES in good shoes. They sit on folding chairs behind the video village and do not take their sunglasses off.

FEIGE, FAVREAU, and a CASTING DIRECTOR (50s, reading glasses, takes no nonsense) watch the monitors. The DOCUMENTARY CREW is here, along the back wall, officially as "Mr. Bullock's personal crew." Nobody has asked who they really are. Yet.

MARC-ANTHONY is in wardrobe: a torn tank top, fake blood, a bandage over his sternum. He's eating a breakfast burrito out of foil and talking to the CRAFT SERVICES GUY about his daughter.

MARC-ANTHONY

— no, see, you gotta let her pick
the science fair project, man. If
you pick it, it's your project.
What's she into?

CRAFT SERVICES GUY

Horses.

MARC-ANTHONY

Horses! Okay. Okay. How many
calories does a horse burn
galloping, versus trotting? You
put a pedometer on a horse. She
wins. What's her name?

CRAFT SERVICES GUY

Destiny.

MARC-ANTHONY

Destiny's winning the science fair.
Tell her I said.

CASTING DIRECTOR (O.S.)

Marc? We're ready.

He hands the burrito to the Craft Services Guy, wipes his hands, and walks onto the cave set. Somewhere between the table and the workbench his face changes. The crew along the back wall

notices it. So does the camera.

Reading opposite him, off-camera as YINSEN, is TAYIA BOYD (24). Marc asked for her specifically. The casting director said no. Feige said yes.

CASTING DIRECTOR
Whenever you're ready. From "Is
it true..."

A long silence. Marc sits at the workbench. He picks up a piece of scrap metal and turns it over in his hands. We wait. The Paramount executives look at each other.

Then:

TAYIA (AS YINSEN)
Is it true what they say? That you
designed every weapon they're
pointing at your country?

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
(not looking up)
Not every one.
(beat)
Some of them I just signed.

TAYIA (AS YINSEN)
And now?

He looks down at the bandage on his chest. He touches it. His fingers shake a little. It isn't a big choice. It's barely anything. On the monitor, it's everything.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
Now I've got a piece of my own
work sitting a half-inch from my
heart.
(a smile, tiny, a wall going up)
Talk about product testing.
(the wall comes down; quieter)
How long?

TAYIA (AS YINSEN)
A week. Maybe.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
A week.
(he laughs, and it's the worst
sound in the room)
I've had hangovers longer than a
week.

He puts the scrap down. Picks up a SCREWDRIVER. Starts to work.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY) (CONT'D)
Okay. Okay. Let's build something.

Nobody says cut for four seconds.

FAVREAU
(finally)
...Cut.

The casting director takes off her reading glasses.

ONE OF THE PARAMOUNT EXECUTIVES leans toward another and whispers something. We can't hear it. The documentary boom mic, pointed at the stage, can't pick it up.

The camera DOES catch Feige's face as he hears it. His jaw sets. That's all.

FAVREAU (CONT'D)
Can we do the press conference scene? The one at the end.

CASTING DIRECTOR
It's not in the sides.

FAVREAU
I know. Marc, you know the ending of the first arc?

MARC-ANTHONY
Tony tells the press he's shutting down weapons manufacturing.

FAVREAU
Just do that. Make it up.

Marc stands. Walks to a spot on the floor. Faces the Paramount executives directly, like they're the press. He gives them one full second of eye contact each.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
I'll keep this short, because I know you all have deadlines, and I know half of you already wrote this story.
(beat)
"Billionaire playboy has a breakdown." "Stark goes soft."
I've read it. I've read it

about myself my whole life.
(steps closer)
Here's what happened. I went
somewhere I wasn't supposed to
come back from. And I came back.
And I saw what I built, and who it
was pointed at.
(beat)
So I'm going to build something
else.
(a grin: the full one)
You're gonna hate it at first.
Everybody does. Then you're gonna
buy the T-shirt.

Silence. One of the Paramount executives takes off his
sunglasses.

FAVREAU
...Yeah. Okay. Cut.

Behind the monitors, Tayia Boyd, script in hand, looks at
the documentary camera. Her eyes are wet. She mouths:
"Told you."

SCENE 6

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS — HALLWAY OUTSIDE STAGE 5 — DAY
WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 16, 2006 — 12:22 PM PT

DAVID MAISEL comes out of the stage and nearly walks into the
DOCUMENTARY CAMERA.

MAISEL
Who are you?

DIRECTOR (O.S.)
We're making a documentary.

MAISEL
About what?

DIRECTOR (O.S.)
Child stars. Growing up. We've
been following Marc since April.

Maisel looks at the camera the way a banker looks at a
spreadsheet that doesn't add up.

MAISEL
Kevin. KEVIN.

FEIGE comes out, with his Handycam in his hand.

MAISEL (CONT'D)
There's a film crew in the
hallway.

FEIGE
I know. They've been here since
nine.

MAISEL
You KNEW?

FEIGE
He asked if they could come.
I said yes.

MAISEL
Kevin, if one frame of this –

FEIGE
It won't.

MAISEL
You can't know that.

Feige looks at the camera, then at the Handycam in his own
hand. Then back at Maisel.

FEIGE
David. If this works – if the
thing on the wall works – nobody
is going to believe how it started.
The Mercedes dealership. The eight
chairs. The kid in the cave set.
Nobody will believe it.
(beat)
Somebody should write it down.

MAISEL
That's what your camcorder's for.

FEIGE
My camcorder shoots the ceiling
half the time.
(to the DIRECTOR, off-camera)
Would you sign something?

DIRECTOR (O.S.)

What kind of something?

FEIGE

Everything you shoot about us
stays sealed. Not for a year. Until
it's over. And when it's over, you
get everything.

DIRECTOR (O.S.)

How long until it's over?

Feige thinks about it. He actually counts something on his
fingers.

FEIGE

...A while.

DOCUMENT INSERT | AGREEMENT: CONFIDENTIALITY AND DEFERRED RELEASE

*Between Marvel Studios, LLC and the Production. Executed Friday, August 18, 2006, 4:40 PM PT. All
footage involving Marvel Studios personnel, productions, or talent shall be sealed and held in escrow
until "the conclusion of the narrative arc presently contemplated by Marvel Studios," as determined in
writing by Marvel Studios' Executive Vice President of Production.*

Signed: David Maisel · Kevin Feige · [the Director]

Handwritten in the margin, initialed "K.F.": "Trust me."

SCENE 7

EXT. RANCHO CIENEGA PARK — BASKETBALL COURTS — SOUTH L.A. —
EARLY EVENING
SUNDAY, AUGUST 27, 2006 — 6:31 PM PT

Heat coming off the asphalt. A pickup game just ended. The
chain nets are still swinging.

MARC-ANTHONY and AMOND BAKER (24) sit on the bottom row of the
bleachers. Amond is sweating through a Juilliard T-shirt. Marc
has a Gatorade he isn't drinking.

It's been eleven days since the screen test. Nobody has called.

AMOND

They're not gonna call on a
Sunday.

MARC-ANTHONY

Kevin Feige calls on Sundays.
Kevin Feige called my mom on
his BIRTHDAY.

AMOND

That's a Feige thing, not a
Sunday thing.

MARC-ANTHONY

Everything's a Feige thing.

A long pause. A kid on the court shoots and misses.

AMOND

Baker's Dozen's done.

Marc turns.

MARC-ANTHONY

What?

AMOND

UPN goes off the air on the
fifteenth. The CW picked up two
UPN shows. We're not one of them.
(shrugs, too casually)
My agent called Friday. She said,
"Honey, you still have your
SPLAT! residuals."

MARC-ANTHONY

Your SPLAT! residuals are four
dollars.

AMOND

Four dollars and eleven cents.

Marc-Anthony puts his arm around Amond's neck and pulls him
into a headlock, the same way he has since they were five.

MARC-ANTHONY

Juilliard. Four years. You did
Lear. You did LEAR, Amond. At
twenty-three. And they're
offering you "Guy Who Says
'Daaamn' in the Background."

AMOND

(muffled)

It's actually "Friend Number
Two Who Says 'Daaamn.'"

MARC-ANTHONY
FRIEND NUMBER TWO?

He lets go. They both sit back, breathing.

AMOND
(quiet)
If you get this –

MARC-ANTHONY
Don't.

AMOND
If you get it. They're making
more than one. You know they are.
Nobody locks a studio up with
Merrill Lynch for one movie about
one guy.

MARC-ANTHONY
I don't know anything.

AMOND
You know something. You always
know something. You've got the
face.

MARC-ANTHONY
What face?

AMOND
The face you had when you were
eight and you knew where your mom
hid the Christmas presents.

Marc-Anthony looks at the court. He doesn't deny it.

MARC-ANTHONY
If I get it... and if there's
more than one... I'm gonna say
your name so many times in that
building they'll have to put you
in a movie just to shut me up.

AMOND
Don't do that.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm gonna do it.

AMOND
You're always gonna do it.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm always gonna do it.

TALKING HEAD

EXT. RANCHO CIENEGA PARK — BLEACHERS — DUSK

LOWER THIRD: AMOND BAKER
Actor • Age 24
Recorded Sunday, August 27, 2006

Alone now. The court lights have come on.

AMOND
People think I'm his sidekick.
On SPLAT!, on Brainiac, I was
literally his sidekick. It was
in my contract.
(small smile)
He was never the lead in real
life. Not with me. When we were
seven, he got a bike for his
birthday, and the first thing he
did was teach me to ride it. Not
him. Me. He rode it second.
(looks away)
So yeah. I want him to get this
so bad I can't sleep.
(beat)
And I'm scared of what happens to
me if he does. Both things. Put
both things in.

SCENE 8

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS — THE CONFERENCE ROOM — DAY
MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 18, 2006 — 3:30 PM PT

(The CW launches tonight. Nobody in this room cares.)

THE DECISION.

The eight chairs are all full: AVI ARAD, DAVID MAISEL, KEVIN
FEIGE, JON FAVREAU, and four PARAMOUNT EXECUTIVES, including
the PARAMOUNT MARKETING PRESIDENT (50s, sharp, fair, and not

pleased).

The DOCUMENTARY CREW is in the corner under the new agreement. The Paramount people do not know what the agreement is. They were told "Marvel archival."

On the table: headshots. One is Marc-Anthony. The others are face-down. We never see them.

PARAMOUNT MARKETING PRESIDENT

I want to be clear that I love the tape. Everyone loves the tape. My assistant watched the tape and called her mother.

(beat)

I'm not here to talk about the tape. I'm here to talk about the one-sheet. I have to put a face on the poster for a character nobody's heard of, from a company that's never made a movie, in a genre that just watched Superman take a two-hundred-million-dollar face plant. And the face I'm putting on the poster, to most of America, is a Disney Channel kid who told a [BLEEP] joke about the Pope on HBO in March.

FAVREAU

It was a good joke.

PARAMOUNT MARKETING PRESIDENT

It was a GREAT joke, Jon. That's the problem.

MAISEL

Your concern is the audience.

PARAMOUNT MARKETING PRESIDENT

My concern is the international audience. My concern is Germany, Japan, Korea, Russia. My concern is that I've sat in this business twenty-two years and I know what the foreign sales people are going to say.

A silence. Everyone in the room knows what she means. Nobody says it.

Feige, who hasn't spoken, puts down his Diet Coke.

FEIGE

Can I say something?

ARAD

Kevin always says something.

FEIGE

Tony Stark, in the comics, is the smartest man in the room, the funniest man in the room, and the most scared man in the room, and he hides the third thing with the first two. That's the character. That's forty-three years of the character.

(beat)

I've read every one of them. I have a list of every actor anyone in this building has suggested, and I've watched everything every one of them has done. And there is one person on that list who is all three of those things at the same time, on camera, without trying.

(he taps the headshot)

He has an engineering degree. He put his money in Apple when everybody said Apple was dead. He wrote, directed and starred in a movie at twenty-three that won at Sundance. He is Tony Stark. He's not playing him. He IS him.

PARAMOUNT MARKETING PRESIDENT

Kevin, respectfully, the kids on the forums –

FEIGE

The kids on the forums will be angry for eighteen months. And then they'll see him in the cave.

(beat)

And about the other thing.

The room goes very still.

FEIGE (CONT'D)

The other thing nobody's saying. If the only reason not to cast the best person is the thing nobody's saying out loud... then

that's not a reason. That's a habit. And we're a company that's never made a movie. We don't have habits yet.

A long silence. The Paramount executives look at Arad. Arad has been sitting with his arms folded the whole time, sunglasses on.

He takes the sunglasses off.

ARAD

For ten years, every studio in this town came to me and said, "Avi, let us decide what's good for your characters." And I said no.

(beat)

I didn't say no to a hundred million dollars so I could say yes to a focus group.

(to Paramount)

You distribute. We decide. That was the deal. That's still the deal.

(to Feige)

Call the kid.

Feige is already standing.

MAISEL

Kevin. Wait until the paper's done. Wednesday. Let his mother and I do the paper first.

Feige sits back down, slowly. He's vibrating.

FEIGE

Wednesday.

MEDIA INSERT: THE TRADES HEAR SOMETHING

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY (Nikki Finke) | Tuesday, September 19, 2006, 11:58 PM PT

Marvel's 'Iron Man' Casting Is Close, And Paramount Is Sweating

Hearing from multiple sources that Marvel has made its choice for Tony Stark over its distributor's objections, and that the choice will "shock the town." Paramount's marketing team was "overruled in the room," per one insider. Marvel's Arad and Maisel are keeping it tight. I'll know by Friday. I always do.

THE VELVET ROPE | Wednesday, September 20, 2006, 8:15 AM

HAPPY BIRTHDAY, ESTHER SMILLEY! 🎂 24 TODAY

America's Little Sweetheart is a grown woman, and Velvet has never seen her look so gorgeous. Spotted at her low-key party last night: the Bullock siblings, the whole Brainiac crew, and a certain best friend who arrived first and left last... Just saying, Marc. Just saying. 💋

SCENE 9

INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL LOS ANGELES — 4 WEST, THE PLAYROOM

— EVENING

WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 27, 2006 — 6:14 PM PT

A bright playroom with murals of hot-air balloons. Kids in hospital gowns and bandanas on beanbags. Some have IV poles. One has a Spider-Man pillow from home.

MARC-ANTHONY sits cross-legged on the floor, reading a Batman comic out loud and doing every voice. This is where his backend from the HBO special went. He comes every Wednesday. The nurses have stopped treating him like a visitor.

MARC-ANTHONY

(as the Joker, terrible)

"Why so SERIOUS, Batsy?"

KID #1 (DEVONTE, 8)

That's not what he says.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's what he SHOULD say. I'm improving the Joker. I'm giving him notes.

KID #2 (LILY, 6)

Do the Batman voice again.

MARC-ANTHONY
(gravel voice)
"I am vengeance. I am the night.
I am... going to need a snack."

The kids crack up. His BLACKBERRY buzzes. He looks. Stops smiling. Stands.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
Devonte, you're Batman now.
Protect the city. I'll be right
back.

INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL – HALLWAY OUTSIDE THE PLAYROOM –
CONTINUOUS

He walks a few steps. The DOCUMENTARY CAMERA follows. He answers.

MARC-ANTHONY
This is Marc.

INTERCUT WITH:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS – FEIGE'S OFFICE – SAME TIME

FEIGE is standing up, because he couldn't sit. FAVREAU sits on the edge of the desk, grinning. ARAD leans in the doorway. MAISEL is on the other side of the window, on a call with Natasha, pretending not to watch.

FEIGE
Marc. It's Kevin.

MARC-ANTHONY
Hey. Hey, Kevin.

A beat.

FEIGE
Do you want to be Tony Stark?

Marc-Anthony doesn't say anything. In the hallway, he puts one hand flat against the wall, like the building might tip over.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Marc?

MARC-ANTHONY
[BLEEP] YES!

It echoes down the entire hallway. A NURSE at the station

drops a clipboard. From the playroom, eleven children cheer at a word they aren't allowed to say.

NURSE

MR. BULLOCK!

MARC-ANTHONY

(to the nurse)

I'm SO sorry. I'm so sorry. I'm sorry, Ms. Delgado.

(into the phone)

I'm sorry. Kevin, I'm sorry, I'm in a children's hospital, I just yelled – in a children's hospital –

In Feige's office, Favreau is laughing so hard he has to sit down on the floor.

FEIGE

It's okay. It's okay. We know.

(beat)

It's not public until Friday. Six A.M. Pacific. You can't tell anybody.

MARC-ANTHONY

I just told a pediatric oncology ward.

FEIGE

Can they keep a secret?

Marc looks through the playroom window. DEVONTE, in a paper cape, is standing on a beanbag protecting the city.

MARC-ANTHONY

Better than anybody I know.

FEIGE

Then you can tell them.

(quieter)

Marc. Your mom's still with David. She's been on the phone with him for six hours. It's not done. Don't celebrate yet.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's my mom. It's done.

INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL – THE PLAYROOM – MOMENTS LATER

Marc-Anthony comes back in. Crouches in the middle of the

kids. Whispers.

MARC-ANTHONY

Okay. Everybody. Superhero secret.
Nobody can know until Friday. You
ready?

Eleven solemn faces. Lily holds up her pinky.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

...I'm gonna be Iron Man.

DEVONTE

Who's Iron Man?

Beat.

MARC-ANTHONY

(to the camera)

See? This is what I'm up against.

SCENE 10: THE CALLS

A SERIES OF SHOTS — WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 27, 2006

— 6:31 PM PT. INT. MARC'S BUICK — HOSPITAL PARKING
STRUCTURE.

He calls GRACE. We hear her pick up. He doesn't even get
a word out.

GRACE (V.O.)

YOU GOT IT. YOU GOT IT. MOM TOLD
ME. SHE TOLD ME NOT TO TELL YOU
SHE TOLD ME. I'M TELLING YOU. I'M
IN A CAB. I'M COMING. I'M TELLING
THE DRIVER. SIR. SIR, MY BROTHER
IS IRON —

MARC-ANTHONY

GRACE —

GRACE (V.O.)

— MAN —

Marc holds the phone away from his ear. On the other end, a
cab driver can be heard saying, very calmly, "Congratulations."

— 6:40 PM PT. SAME.

He calls AMOND. Amond answers on the first ring.

AMOND (V.O.)
...Yeah?

MARC-ANTHONY
Yeah.

A long silence on the line. Then we hear Amond breathe out, very slowly, like he's been holding his breath since August.

AMOND (V.O.)
Okay.
(beat)
Okay. Okay.

MARC-ANTHONY
You're crying.

AMOND (V.O.)
I'm chopping onions.

MARC-ANTHONY
You don't cook.

AMOND (V.O.)
I'm starting tonight.

— 6:52 PM PT. SAME.

He scrolls to a name: "ESTHER." His thumb hovers. He presses it.

ESTHER (V.O.)
Hi.

MARC-ANTHONY
Hey. Happy late birthday.

ESTHER (V.O.)
You were at my birthday.

MARC-ANTHONY
Happy late birthday again.

A pause. She can hear it in his voice. She's known him since they were ten.

ESTHER (V.O.)
...Marc. Did you get it?

MARC-ANTHONY

I can't say.

ESTHER (V.O.)

(smiling, you can hear it)

You got it.

MARC-ANTHONY

I can't say, Esther.

ESTHER (V.O.)

I'm so proud of you I could
scream.

MARC-ANTHONY

Grace already did the screaming.
We're covered on screaming.

ESTHER (V.O.)

Then I'll do the other thing.

(beat)

I always knew. Since The Kid Who
Stole Christmas. You fixed the
sleigh with a paper clip when the
prop broke and the director almost
fired you and you were ten.
I always knew.

Marc-Anthony doesn't say anything for a moment. He just
listens to her breathe on the line.

MARC-ANTHONY

Thanks, Esther.

ESTHER (V.O.)

Go home. Eat something that isn't
a pancake.

He hangs up. Sits in the car. Looks at the camera.

MARC-ANTHONY

Don't.

DIRECTOR (O.S.)

We didn't say anything.

MARC-ANTHONY

You were gonna.

SCENE 11

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT — THE CRENSHAW LOT — THE BOARD ROOM — NIGHT

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 28, 2006 — 10:47 PM PT

THE PAPER.

A long table, cold coffee, legal pads. NATASHA (45) at one end, in reading glasses, with the DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT GENERAL COUNSEL beside her. DAVID MAISEL at the other end, with Marvel's BUSINESS AFFAIRS lawyer. It's hour eleven of day two.

The documentary camera: both sides agreed to it, under the seal. Neither side trusts the other one not to perform for it.

MAISEL

Paragraph fourteen.

NATASHA

Paragraph fourteen goes.

MAISEL

Paragraph fourteen is standard.

NATASHA

Paragraph fourteen is a morality clause that lets you fire my son for "conduct that brings the production into public disrepute." His HBO special is conduct that brought HBO into public disrepute. HBO made nine million dollars.

MAISEL

It's boilerplate.

NATASHA

David. I have read that boilerplate on forty contracts in this town, for forty Black actors, and I have watched it get used on eleven of them. It doesn't get used on the other ones.

(beat)

It goes. Or he does.

A long silence. Maisel looks at his lawyer. The lawyer looks at the ceiling. Maisel crosses out paragraph fourteen with one line.

MAISEL
Paragraph nineteen.

NATASHA
The options.

MAISEL
Sequel protection.

NATASHA
Nine pictures, David.

MAISEL
It's an option. It protects
both sides.

NATASHA
(takes off her reading glasses)
Nine pictures. For one movie. With
escalating fees through two
thousand nineteen. And a clause
that says my son may be required
to "appear in productions featuring
other Marvel characters."
(beat)
You're not making a movie. You're
building something.

Maisel doesn't answer. He looks at the documentary camera,
then back at Natasha.

MAISEL
I can't talk about that.

NATASHA
You just did.
(she puts the glasses back on)
Fine. Nine pictures. Here's what
I want. The escalators double.
Back-end on every picture he
appears in, not just his own.
Approval over his stunt coordinator.
He does his own stunts, and he
trains with the best people alive,
and if anybody tells him to use a
double to save money, I get a
phone call.
(beat)
And his name goes on the building.

MAISEL
What building?

NATASHA
Whatever building you end up
building.

Maisel almost smiles. Almost.

MAISEL
...Everything but the building.

NATASHA
Everything but the building,
for now.

She signs. It's 11:52 PM. She checks her watch and says it
out loud for the record.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
Eleven fifty-two. Thursday,
September twenty-eighth.
(to the camera)
Write it down.

TALKING HEAD

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT — NATASHA'S OFFICE — NIGHT

LOWER THIRD: NATASHA BULLOCK
CEO, Donohue Entertainment · Mother · Age 45
Recorded Thursday, September 28, 2006, 11:58 PM

Shoes off. A glass of wine she hasn't touched.

NATASHA
My father built this company
because Hollywood wouldn't give
him a leading role.
(beat)
Thirty years later his grandson
is the lead in a two-hundred-
million-dollar gamble that the
whole town is going to root
against. And I'm the one who
signed the paper.
(looks at her hands)
If it fails, they'll say he wasn't
ready. If it works, they'll say he
was lucky.
(a small, hard smile)

So it's going to work so well
they can't say anything.

SCENE 12

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — KITCHEN — BALDWIN HILLS — DAWN
FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 — 5:59 AM PT

We're back. The pancakes are cold. The crew is still here.
Marc-Anthony is standing at the counter with his BlackBerry.

GRACE (22) is asleep on the kitchen floor on a pile of couch
cushions, where she's been since 2 AM. She still has her
shoes on.

The microwave clock changes to 6:00.

The BlackBerry buzzes. And keeps buzzing. It doesn't stop.

Marc reads the screen. Then reads it out loud, very quietly.

MARC-ANTHONY
"Marvel Studios today announced
that Marc-Anthony Bullock will
star as Tony Stark in Iron Man..."

Grace sits bolt upright on the floor.

GRACE
IS IT OUT?

MARC-ANTHONY
It's out.

Grace screams. It's a Tony-winning, four-octave scream. A
dog two houses away starts barking. Marc starts laughing. Then
he stops laughing, sits down on the kitchen floor next to his
sister, and puts his face in his hands.

Grace wraps both arms around his head.

GRACE
I know. I know. I know.

The BlackBerry keeps buzzing on the counter above them. They
let it.

MEDIA INSERT: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006

PR NEWSWIRE | Friday, September 29, 2006, 9:00 AM ET / 6:00 AM PT

MARVEL STUDIOS CASTS MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK AS TONY STARK IN "IRON MAN"

LOS ANGELES — Marvel Studios today announced that Marc-Anthony Bullock (*The Long Way Home*, *Brainiac*) will star as billionaire inventor Tony Stark in *Iron Man*, directed by Jon Favreau. The film will begin principal photography in March 2007 and is scheduled for release by Paramount Pictures on **May 2, 2008**. "Tony Stark is a genius, a showman, and a man who has to rebuild himself," said Kevin Feige, Executive Vice President of Production at Marvel Studios. "Marc-Anthony is the only actor we met who was all of those things before he walked in the room."

VARIETY | Friday, September 29, 2006, 6:04 AM PT

MARVEL'S 'IRON' MAN: 'BRAINIAC' STAR BULLOCK TO SUIT UP

Former Disney Channel star and Sundance-winning filmmaker lands the lead in Marvel Studios' first self-financed tentpole, a surprise choice that will make him, at 24, one of the youngest actors ever to headline a \$140 million picture. Deal is understood to include options on multiple films.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER | September 29, 2006

MARVEL BETS \$140 MILLION ON THE 'BRAINIAC' KID

Studio overrules distributor Paramount on its first casting decision. "It's either the smartest thing anyone's done in this town in ten years or the most expensive children's party ever thrown," said one rival exec.

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY (Nikki Finke) | September 29, 2006, 6:11 AM PT

TOLDJA! It's Bullock.

I told you Tuesday it would shock the town. It shocked the town. Paramount's marketing department is currently lying on the floor. Here's what nobody's reporting: Bullock's deal is for NINE pictures. NINE. For ONE movie. Why would a company making one movie need nine? Somebody at Marvel is either building something very big or very stupid. Stay tuned.

MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT (NYSE: MVL) | Close, Friday, September 29, 2006

Shares close up **3.1%** on heavy volume. One analyst: "The market doesn't know if it's a good idea. It just knows it's an idea."

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS | September 29, 2006, 8:30 AM CT

THE BRAINIAC KID IS TONY STARK. I'M... ACTUALLY IN?

Three months ago I told you I spat out my coffee. Since then I've watched everything he's done: *The Long Way Home* three times, the HBO special twice (my mom walked in on the second one, that was fun), and every episode of *Brainiac* I could find on bootleg. Here's my verdict: this kid is Tony Stark. He IS the smartest guy in the room who can't stop talking. If he can do the cave, we have a movie. Marvel, you crazy bastards. I think you did it.

COMIC BOOK RESOURCES | *September 29, 2006*

FAN REACTION ROUNDUP: 'Iron Man' casting splits the Internet

Our poll (19,221 votes by noon): 41% LOVE IT, 22% WAIT AND SEE, 37% HATE IT.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM | *September 29, 2006, 6:31 AM PT*

SERVICE UNAVAILABLE.

The server is temporarily unable to service your request due to maintenance downtime or capacity problems. Please try again later.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM FORUMS (*back online 7:48 AM PT*) › **"OFFICIAL: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK IS TONY STARK"**

Page 1 of 1,164

ShellHead_1963 — Sep 29 2006, 7:49 AM

I CALLED IT IN JUNE. JUNE. I have the receipts. Page 88, casting thread #4. Go look.

XxWolverineXx — Sep 29 2006, 7:50 AM

I will be driving to Beverly Hills as promised. Does anybody have a tire iron.

ShellHead_1963 — Sep 29 2006, 7:51 AM

@XxWolverineXx you don't have a car. you told us. in 2004.

XxWolverineXx — Sep 29 2006, 7:52 AM

I will be TAKING THE BUS to Beverly Hills as promised

DarkReign_Dan — Sep 29 2006, 8:03 AM

Tony Stark is white. It's been that way for 43 years. Marvel is doing this for PC points and it's going to bomb and it's going to take the whole Marvel movie thing down with it.

Rhodey4WarMachine — Sep 29 2006, 8:05 AM

@DarkReign_Dan Tony Stark is a genius engineer, a billionaire, a showman, and a drunk. Name one of those four things that's white. I'll wait.

ExcelsiorFaithful — Sep 29 2006, 8:09 AM

I care about ONE thing and ONE thing only and I've been saying it since April. Is the STORY comic accurate? Is the SUIT comic accurate? Is the ARMOR comic accurate? Race was never in the comic's DNA. Engineering was. Guy has an ACTUAL engineering degree. I'm cautiously in.

DarkReign_Dan — Sep 29 2006, 8:11 AM

Tony Stark was created by Stan Lee in 1963 and—

Mjolnir_Worthy — Sep 29 2006, 8:12 AM

Stan Lee created Tony Stark to be the kind of guy the audience would HATE and then make them love him anyway. Congrats you're the audience. Mod please.

[MODERATOR] — Sep 29 2006, 8:14 AM

DarkReign_Dan has been suspended for 7 days. Keep it about the movie, people. Casting debate is fine. That wasn't debate.

PepperPottsFanClub — Sep 29 2006, 8:30 AM

Somebody please tell me they're getting Tayia Boyd for Pepper. Marcus and Keisha. BRAINIAC REUNION. I will see this movie 40 times.

XxWolverineXx — Sep 29 2006, 8:33 AM

Hot take: this is not "the first Marvel movie," it's "the first Disney Channel Original Movie with a \$140 million budget"

ShellHead_1963 — Sep 29 2006, 8:34 AM

Hot take: you're going to be first in line.

XxWolverineXx — Sep 29 2006, 8:35 AM

...yeah probably

YOUTUBE | *Uploaded Sep 29, 2006 · 34,112 views (by 11:00 PM)*

"BRAINIAC KID IS IRON MAN?!?! (MY REACTION) 🤪🤪🤪" — by **TrueBelieverTV**

Top comment, **mrs_hayes_4ever**: go back and watch season 2 episode 7 of brainiac. HE BUILDS A SUIT OF ARMOR. HE SAYS "ONE DAY A MAN WILL FLY IN A SUIT OF ARMOR." IN 1996. what is going on

Reply, **TrueBelieverTV**: ...I'm making a second video

MYSPACE | *Profile status, Marc-Anthony Bullock Official (1,108,442 friends), Sep 29, 2006, 9:02 AM*

Mood: 🤪 overwhelmed

Headline: "one day a man will fly in a suit of armor." — me, age 14. I kept the helmet. 🧡 thank u kevin, thank u jon, thank u mom, thank u grace (sorry about the scream), and amond, always amond.

TWITTER (six months old; a few thousand users, mostly in San Francisco)

@jkaplan_sf — 9:47 AM Sep 29th, 2006

the brainiac kid is iron man. what a timeline

EXTRA / ACCESS HOLLYWOOD / E! NEWS (evening shows, Friday, September 29, 2006)

The segment runs 40 seconds on all three: the Brainiac science-fair clip, the HBO special, the Sundance photo, and the question every anchor asks in some version: "Can the kid from Disney Channel carry a superhero movie?"

SHOWBIZ TONIGHT (CNN Headline News) | Friday, September 29, 2006, 11:00 PM ET

TONIGHT'S DEBATE: IS HOLLYWOOD'S NEWEST SUPERHERO TOO YOUNG, TOO RAUNCHY, OR JUST RIGHT?

A pop-culture critic: "Marvel has cast the most famous child star in America in a movie about a man who has to prove he's not a child. That's either genius or a disaster."

SCENE 13

INT. D1 STUDIOS — "ELXA AFTER DARK" — STAGE 3 — THE CRENSHAW
LOT — NIGHT

FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 — 10:00 PM PT (LIVE)

A gold-and-black late-night set. A velvet couch. A live band.
Three hundred people in the audience, all of whom know exactly
whose sister this is.

ELXA BULLOCK (26, a month older), in a gown with a train,
walks to her mark. The applause does not stop. She lets it go
a little longer than she should, on purpose.

ELXA

Thank you. Thank you. Sit down.
No, keep going, actually, I'm
enjoying it.

(it dies down)

So. Some of you may have heard.
My baby brother is Iron Man.

HUGE applause.

ELXA (CONT'D)

I have so many feelings. My first
feeling was pride. My second
feeling was, "Wait, isn't Iron
Man the one who's a billionaire
genius with a drinking problem and
a new girlfriend every week?"
And I thought, "Well, that's not
acting, that's a documentary."

Laughter.

ELXA (CONT'D)

No, that's not true. That's not
true at all. My brother's a
sweetheart. My brother is the
sweetest person you'll ever meet.
He cries at commercials. He cried
at a Hallmark commercial on
Tuesday, and it wasn't even one of
the sad ones. It was about a
birthday card.

(beat)

Also, he has the filthiest mouth
in the United States of America.
He's banned from two Olive
Gardens. For LANGUAGE.

(to the camera)
Marvel, you have no idea what you
just did. And I love you for it.
(softer, and she means it)
I'm really proud of you, Marc.
Don't let anybody tell you you're
too young, or too funny, or too
anything. You were always gonna be
the one.
(then, turning on a dime)
Now let's talk about Britney.

SCENE 14 (CLOSING)

INT. THE CRENSHAW LOT – THE LAUNDROMAT MUSEUM – NIGHT
FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 – 11:48 PM PT

The original 1966 building. Still has the washing machines lining one wall, now behind velvet ropes, each with a gold record hanging over it. A single desk in the middle: VICTOR's first desk. A rotary phone. A framed dollar bill.

MARC-ANTHONY sits on top of one of the old dryers, still in the hoodie from this morning. He's come here to hide from the BlackBerry, which has 612 unread messages.

The door opens. VICTOR DONOHUE (70), in a cardigan over his pajamas, a flashlight in one hand, like he's done this before.

VICTOR
Security called me. Said somebody
broke into the museum.

MARC-ANTHONY
I have a key, Grandpa.

VICTOR
I know. I gave it to you. I told
them to call me anyway.

Victor lowers himself into the chair behind his old desk, slowly. He sets the flashlight down, pointing at the ceiling.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
How many people told you you
were going to fail today?

MARC-ANTHONY
Like... on the internet?

VICTOR

Anywhere.

MARC-ANTHONY

I stopped counting at the guy who wanted to take the bus to Beverly Hills to hit me with a tire iron.

VICTOR

Good number.

(beat)

In nineteen sixty-six, I had a thousand dollars and a lease on a laundromat. Every man I knew in this business told me a Black man from the South Side couldn't own his own record company in Los Angeles. They were very sure about it. They told me very kindly, the way you tell a child the stove is hot.

(beat)

They were all very sure. And they're all dead now. And I'm sitting at this desk.

Marc laughs despite himself.

MARC-ANTHONY

That's dark, Grandpa.

VICTOR

That's time, grandson. Time is the only critic that matters.

(leans forward)

They're going to wait for you to fail. For a year and a half, every one of them is going to sit there, waiting. Let them wait. Waiting is all they know how to do.

(beat)

You know how to build.

Marc looks down at his hands.

MARC-ANTHONY

Grandpa, I want what you have.

VICTOR

The company?

MARC-ANTHONY

The table. The birthday table.
Everybody around it. I want a
table so long you can't see the
end of it. I want kids. I want so
many kids. I want my kids' kids
to never have to ask anybody for
anything.

(beat)

And I want them to know the guy at
the head of the table was worth
something. Not the Brainiac kid.
Not the guy who curses on HBO.
The guy who built something.

Victor looks at his grandson for a long time.

VICTOR

Own the masters. Own the land.
Own the name.

(beat)

Then go build your table.

He picks up the flashlight and stands.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

And go home. Your grandmother is
going to call your mother about
what you said at the children's
hospital, and I don't want to be
awake for it.

MARC-ANTHONY

How does she already know about
that?

VICTOR

Son, she's your grandmother. She
knew about it before you said it.

Victor walks out. The door swings closed. Marc-Anthony is
alone with the washing machines and the gold records.

He looks at the camera.

MARC-ANTHONY

Five hundred and nineteen days.
(off the DIRECTOR's silence)
Until May second, two thousand
eight. I did the math on the
way over.
(beat)

I'm gonna use every single one.

He hops down off the dryer, pats it twice like a horse, and walks out into the dark lot.

FADE OUT.

TAG: TALKING HEAD

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — HIS CLOSET — NIGHT

LOWER THIRD: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK
Actor, "Tony Stark" · Age 24
Recorded Saturday, September 30, 2006, 1:12 AM

A walk-in closet. Sneakers, organized by color. On the top shelf, in a Ziploc bag: a battered TINFOIL-AND-CARDBOARD HELMET from 1996.

He takes it down. Holds it up to the camera.

MARC-ANTHONY
Brainiac, season two, episode seven. "Science Fair-y Tale."
(turns it around; a dent in the side)
That's from the judge's foot.
Mr. Kowalski. He sued.
(beat)
He didn't sue. I'm kidding.
He sent me a Christmas card every year until he died.
(a long look at the helmet)
I'm gonna tell you something and then you gotta turn it off, because I'm gonna cry and I already cried in front of a nurse today.
(beat)
Everybody thinks I'm the Brainiac kid. They're right. I am.
(he puts the tinfoil helmet on; it's too small; it sits on top of his head like a hat)
He just grew up.
(pause; the helmet slips)
...Okay, turn it off. Turn it off.
Grace is gonna see this and she's never gonna let me —

CUT TO BLACK.

THE LEDGER: CHAPTER ONE TIMELINE

Date & time (PT)	Event	Ages
Fri, Apr 28, 2006, 6:00 AM	Marvel Studios announces <i>Iron Man</i> , its first film, with Jon Favreau directing	Feige 32 · Arad 58 · Favreau 39 · Stan Lee 83
Fri, Apr 28, 2006, 11:32 AM	Marc turns down <i>Double Bogey</i> , the 8th comedy	Marc 24 · Barry Kessler 57
Tue, May 30, 2006, 7:48 PM	Victor's 70th birthday dinner; Natasha has "made two calls"	Victor 70 · Joan 68 · Robert 47 · Natasha 44 · Elxa 25 · Marc 24 · Grace 22
Fri, Jun 2, 2006, 10:05 AM	Feige calls Natasha; they share a birthday	Natasha 45 · Feige 33
Fri, Jun 30, 2006	AICN first reports the Bullock rumor	—
Thu, Jul 13, 2006, 2:10 PM	Marc meets Favreau and Feige: "PLAY THE CAVE"	Marc 24 · Favreau 39 · Feige 33
Wed, Aug 16, 2006, 9:58 AM	The screen test at Raleigh Studios, with Tayia Boyd reading Yinsen	Marc 24 · Tayia 24
Fri, Aug 18, 2006, 4:40 PM	The sealing agreement is signed	—
Sun, Aug 27, 2006, 6:31 PM	Marc and Amond on the court; <i>Baker's Dozen</i> is canceled	Amond 24
Tue, Aug 29, 2006	Elxa turns 26	Elxa 26
Mon, Sep 18, 2006, 3:30 PM	The decision: Arad overrules Paramount. " <i>Call the kid.</i> "	—
Wed, Sep 20, 2006	Esther turns 24	Esther 24
Wed, Sep 27, 2006, 6:14 PM	The call, at Children's Hospital Los Angeles	Marc 24
Thu, Sep 28, 2006, 11:52 PM	Natasha signs the nine-picture deal; paragraph 14 is struck	Natasha 45
Fri, Sep 29, 2006, 6:00 AM	Marvel announces Marc-Anthony Bullock as Tony Stark	Marc 24 · Grace 22
Fri, Sep 29, 2006, 6:31 AM	SuperHeroHype crashes	—
Fri, Sep 29, 2006, 10:00 PM	<i>Elxa After Dark</i> (live)	Elxa 26

Date & time (PT)	Event	Ages
Fri, Sep 29, 2006, 11:48 PM	Marc and Victor in the laundromat museum	Victor 70 · Marc 24

Days until *Iron Man* opens (May 2, 2008): 581 from Sep 29, 2006. (*Marc's "519" is wrong: he did the math in his head while driving, and Grace will point it out in Chapter Two.*)

NEXT: CHAPTER TWO

October 2006 → March 2007: Pepper, preparation, and the road to Day One.